

drive's performance with such applications.

Here the 52x **ASUS CD-S520G** drive fared well, logging 30.12 seconds to open the images, making it 23 seconds faster than the slowest drive in this test. The second in this test was the 52x Krypton, which trailed very slightly, taking 34.28 seconds to open the images from the CD.

The drive that took the most time to complete this test was the 52x Samsung SC-152, taking a slow 53.56 seconds to open all the TIFF images.

In summary, we see that the real world performance of these drives is often different from the synthetic or 'ideal-conditions' performance. If you work extensively with applications where you need to copy and read files from the CD-ROM drive, then the best choice in this category would be the Krypton 52x drive as it showed exemplary performance in the file transfer as well as the Photoshop tests and is also priced quite competitively. The runner up in this category was the 52x ASUS CD-S520.

CONCLUSION

The performance of a CD drive is not just a function of the maximum speed it can reach in synthetic tests but also in real world performance tests and in its ability to support new features and formats.

The 50x **ASUS S500/G** drive proved to be the best performer in these tests, having logged a very impressive set of results and was a good blend of performance in the real-world and low-level data transfer tests. In fact, despite being a 50x drive it posted results that were a shade ahead of even some of the 52x drives. It was, however, among the more expensive drives in the comparison.

The 56x **Acer CD 656P** bagged the Best Value award. This drive posted good data transfer speeds and proved to be an exceptional performer, especially for

audio ripping related applications. Its performance was just a shade below that of the winning CD drive and it was quite economically priced. No other 52x drive came close to this one in terms of price for the given level of performance.

Even though CD-ROM drives are at threat due to the aggressive pricing and speeds of DVD drives, they still prove to be worthy performers and it seems that the continually falling prices of these drives will ensure that the CD-ROM standard sticks around for some time to come.

1/2 Pg V AD



Acer CD 656P: a value buy



ASUS S500/G: it blazes ahead